

Pocket Monsters

Tragedies and disasters are motivational oxymorons. They generate this immediate response. An irrepressible urge to fight back. To help. To do something.

But for most of us, there's really nothing to do.

While Danni contacted the league to get Demi pulled from the event, I called her agent to fill him in. As expected, he filed the development away in some mental drawer. An insignificant detail, the weight of which could not be detected atop his already monstrous burden.

Then we drafted a brief press release, which also went largely unnoticed. Demi was the story, to which our part was just a footnote. And that was that.

I felt worse than useless. Like we were adding to the problem instead of helping. For an organization that takes great pride in its family dynamic, we had basically lopped off one of our own with two quick phone calls. Then it was back to work. Business as usual.

It didn't feel right, and it didn't look right, either. The mood on the training floor was notably subdued. Lots of activity, but all of it passive. Like no one's heart was really in it. I did notice Tiz tearing into a heavy bag with more venom than usual, but that looked more like therapy than training.

I looked around for the lightweight group... then realized we no longer had one. The recent retirement of Roselyn Sanchez reduced us to only Emily and Demi at that weight. With Demi out of action, Em was now a group of one. Which showed me yet another benefit of our new format. The old routine was very weight class oriented, which would have left Emily adrift. But the new way was much looser, and I found her tucked in with Emma and Tiffany Mulheron. A good development that should have been great. Three young, popular champions training together? That should have been an event. A private demonstration, put on by three of the very best. But right now, there was really nothing to see. Simple drills and some light sparring. All three interested only in getting through the day.

Danni came up beside me.

"If you're gonna go, you need to go now."

"Go?" I asked.

"To see Demi."

She knows me much too well.

There was no reason to go see Demi. In fact, it probably wasn't appropriate. I didn't know what state she was in. Would she be taking visitors? If so, why would she want me to be one of them?

It was a stupid idea. Not worth pursuing in the slightest.

Yet I still wanted to go, and Danni knew it.

"Now's your only chance," she said. "Once they release her, I'm sure she'll be headed back to rehab."

I never really hesitated after that. As absurd as it was, I wasn't going to be able to shake this feeling. I had to at least give it a shot.

"You've got things here?" I asked.

"Sure," she answered. "Just remember we have that meeting at three."

I closed my eyes and blew out a sigh of frustration.

The meeting was to finalize the signing of our newest recruit. A young woman we had sought out for a number of different reasons, many of which were little more than dead hopes now. The timing would be comical if any of this shit were actually funny.

"I'll be here," I said with a slow nod.

I was turning to go when she spoke again.

"Richelle..."

I turned back to find her looking right at me, and I saw the hollow uselessness I was feeling reflected in her expression.

"Yeah," I said solemnly. "I know."

She never finished her sentence. We exchanged sad nods, and then I went on my way.

In my head, I heard the words she didn't have to say.

You can't fix this one.

* * *

Getting in to see Demi was a lot easier than I'd expected. I contacted her agent again before I left to gauge my odds. He and I knew each other only from brief negotiations before we signed her, but he seemed like a decent guy. He gave me some resistance at first, but, once I made it clear I was coming as nothing more than a friend, he said he could get me past the security working to keep the hordes of media at bay. He couldn't promise anything beyond that.

When I arrived, I went where I was pointed and did what I was told. I waited patiently as harried desk attendants made the requisite phone calls. Once I was allowed through, I was actually escorted to the appropriate wing. There a large chunk of the floor was cutoff, and yet another makeshift security checkpoint had been established. I passed through with little issue.

On the other side, four rooms sat empty. Cleared out to provide a tiny little enclave of calm... and to make room for the security the situation required. A small waiting room to the right buzzed faintly with activity. A half-dozen people I didn't know talking in hushed tones, either to themselves or into their phones. Quietly trying to wrestle this mess into submission. At the end of the hall, Demi's agent stood guard with his cell pressed to his ear. He waved me forward, then gestured beyond with a little good luck shrug.

Just like that, I was standing outside Demi's door... and having serious second thoughts. This was beyond stupid. I didn't belong here.

I cracked the door open to find a totally strung out, middle-aged woman sitting just a few feet inside. A woman whose peaceful slumber had been shattered hours earlier by a phone call she'd long been worried would come. Long, soft strawberry-blonde hair that should have been lustrous was instead tangled and unkempt. An otherwise pretty face was cracked and marred by lines of stress and worry.

She turned tiredly, then her bright brown eyes narrowed to slits the moment she realized she didn't recognize me.

Immediately, I realized I had reached the end of the easy road.

Appearance alone told me who she was, but she confirmed it with the way she sprang from the chair.

"Who are you?" Demi's mother demanded.

"I'm sorry," I said softly. "I didn't mean to intrude."

I backed completely out of the door frame, giving her room to slam the door in my face if that's what she wanted.

"Richelle?"

My heart broke. The voice was weak and small, and I barely recognized it as Demi's.

"Yeah, Demi," I said. "It's OK. We can talk later. I didn't mean..."

"Mom, it's alright," she said. "She's a friend."

I was surprised to hear her use the word. Though she'd been at RSI for years, the truth was that Demi and I didn't know each other nearly as well as we should. A failure I put squarely on me.

Meanwhile, Demi's mother hadn't moved an inch. I understood completely. Demi basically swam with sharks on a regular basis. Normally, the relationship was symbiotic. Demi's success gave the press something to write about. Garnering attention by celebrating tour stops and touting album sales. But the slightest hint of weakness would bring out the media's predator side... and Demi was now badly wounded.

Which meant that no one was getting anywhere near her without mama's say-so.

"I'll go," I said. "It's not a problem."

Demi's voice seemed to gain a little strength.

"Mom, please... it's OK."

Her mother still didn't move.

"It's your call," I said. "The last thing I want to do is cause trouble."

She took her time sizing me up. I waited for her to make up her mind.

Eventually, she opened the door wider and let me pass.

I got my first look at Demi... and she looked like shit.

Strangely, there was no wild knot of tubes that hospitals are known for. Just Demi in the bed, with a single line running from her wrist to an IV. I suppose that's how it works when you poison yourself. If aid comes quickly, then you recover and there's not much else to do. And if the help you need doesn't arrive in a timely manner... well, then I guess there's still not much else to do.

I stood and looked at her for a moment, once again wondering what I was doing here.

"How are you feeling?" I asked - mostly because I didn't know what else to say.

"Better than I have any right to."

Remorse was plainly etched on her face and laced into the tone of her voice. It was the cruelest of tricks. One I'd seen played many times before. A slide that had likely started with Demi feeling lonely and sorry for herself had ended here, with a crystal clear view how just much she actually had... and how badly she'd hurt the people who cared the most about her.

Addictions start out like magical pets. Pocket monsters.

I couldn't remember where I'd read the quote, nor could I recall the rest. Something about how addictions start out fun. How they take away your pain and show you things you've never experienced before. But soon enough, they start to make decisions for you. And, unfortunately, they're dumb as rocks.

Sure I'll have another. I feel great.

Of course, I'm hitting the clubs tonight. It's Friday. I deserve to have some fun.

And so it goes, in a downward spiral that quickly picks up speed... until fun becomes need and reason exits the equation entirely.

After that, there's no stopping until it all concludes in a moment like this. Where something terrible forces the fog to lift, and reality rushes back in. Only then do you realize what you've done... and just how many people you sucked down with you.

Now Demi was left to deal with the pain she'd caused. The fans she'd let down and the friendships she'd damaged. But I was willing to bet the most agonizing part of all was being forced to sit here in this bed and witness what she'd done to her poor mother.

I stepped closer to the bed, and noticed a small, brown ball of fur tucked under her arm. A little stuffed dog. Worn and tattered in a way that suggested it had been around for quite a long time.

She picked it up, and gave it a friendly little wiggle.

"This is Sir Wagsalot," she said. "He and I have been through a lot together."

"Well," I said formally, "hello, Sir Wagsalot."

"You don't have to talk to him," she said. "He's not real."

My eyes narrowed.

"I see you still have your sense of humor."

"I'm trying."

She nestled the toy back in its spot, and I wondered briefly how many hard times it had helped her manage. From skinned knees to her first day of school... and now this. Her version of Linus's security blanket. An anchor to hold on to when life starts to spin too fast.

She let her head fall back onto the pillow. She looked so small and tired and... childlike. Like a little girl, ready to nod off on the couch after a long day. Her favorite stuffed animal snuggled in right there to keep her safe.

If only he had been there for her, last night.

"So, did you come here to fire me, too?" she asked.

The question surprised me... though it probably shouldn't have. No doubt, advertisers and venue operators had been calling all morning. Looking to cut their losses and get away from this mess.

"No," I said firmly.

"Well, that makes you the first," she said.

Again, there was no sense that she was worried about herself. If anything, she sounded like she thought she deserved everything she was getting.

"We're pulling you from the upcoming event, and we'll put you on medical suspension to get you off the active roster for now. But your slot will be waiting when you're ready."

She nodded.

"I appreciate that."

The silence returned. I wanted to fill it, but had nothing to say. Why was I here? What did I hope to accomplish?

"You must have a lot of questions," she said.

I shook my head.

"Why not?"

"Because I know there are no answers."

Her head drooped and then came back up. A nod, or sheer exhaustion taking hold? God, she looked so tired.

Her eyes drifted away, and I thought she she might be nodding off. But then she spoke again.

"You're an addict," she said.

A simple statement, with no accusation behind it. Just her following the clues. First, I seemed more understanding of what had happened than most. On top of that, a good portion of my life had been spent in some very dark places, where I had seen plenty of people lose themselves to drugs and alcohol. And then there was the fact that everyone at RSI knew I didn't drink. Often a tell-tale sign of a recovering addict.

So, it was a reasonable conclusion, and, to be honest, she was not the first to come to it.

But I shook my head. I'd done a lot of things I now regret, but I was conscientious about steering well clear of that particular mistake.

"Then you know someone," she concluded.

I gave her a little smile.

"I don't think now is the right time for this discussion," I said.

She smiled back, and then seemed to drift again. Time passed. Enough that I was sure she was out... until I noticed the tears. Soft and silent. Almost as though she were too weak to spare any more effort.

"I don't know why I keep doing this to myself," she said softly.

And then she fell asleep with her cheeks still wet. Her great protector tucked in by her side.

I felt like shit, and I wasn't even sure why.

"It's been like that all morning," her mother said. "She can't stay awake."

"Yeah," I said. "She's been through a lot."

She nodded absently, looking almost as thoroughly wiped out as her daughter.

"I going to go and leave you in peace," I said. "I'm sorry this happened. To both of you. I wish there was something I could do."

More nodding, but her eyes never left Demi. I wasn't sure she was even hearing me.

I moved toward the door.

"What she said was true," her mother said. "You know someone."

We turned to face each other.

"A friend of mine," I said. "Someone I grew up with."

"Is she better now?"

I really wanted to lie. To let her have the hope she craved.

Instead, I gave no response, which was all the answer she needed.

"Oh," she said. "I'm sorry."

Then she turned back to her sleeping daughter, and I understood exactly what she was feeling. The sadness. The helpless feeling of worrying the worst would eventually come... and there was nothing you could do to stop it.

"It doesn't have to end that way," I said.

She nodded again.

"But it might," she said.